

Amelia Kerr. "The impact is going to take some time to sink in. After the 2000 World Cup win, it took years to see the swell in numbers and interest in cricket to grow. Fingers crossed we can do that back home too and inspire the next generation of players."

Customised changes

It is fair to say the tournament got off to a rather sedate start. A hurried relocation and the fact that it wasn't the actual host nation are reasons cited by the Emirates Cricket Board for why they couldn't go all out with any promotional plans.

Cab journeys would acquaint you with radio adverts for the tournament, which became more frequent over the course of the tournament. Small billboards displaying the mugshots of star players alongside ticket information appeared around the peripheries of the Dubai International Stadium. A significant step up was the India vs Pakistan game, which saw around 16,000 people in attendance.

The tournament made a compelling case for why boundaries need to be pushed back in the women's game. The longer distances meant teams had no choice but to adapt and get their basics right. The inability to clear the ropes frequently, particularly with slow outfielders like in Sharjah, meant that running between the wickets adeptly became even more crucial.

The same applied to the conditions. Low, slow wickets, especially in Sharjah, levelled the contest between bat and ball. Tighter fields, better catching, and bowling at the stumps gave experienced teams multiple opportunities to stay in the game. "The beauty of playing a global game is you're going to play in conditions that are different in every country you go to," Devine said of a tournament that, for much of its duration, was largely devoid of sixes. That eventually changed.

One for the veterans

Across the board, this was a tournament where the senior pros stamped their class and led by

example. Consider Suzie Bates. She didn't have the most runs for New Zealand, but her fearless determination to keep pushing helped create a formidable opening duo alongside Georgia Plimmer.

She was a gun fielder, stationed inside the circle for the most part, putting her body on the line to help the Kiwis be as economical as possible. She even came on to bowl, defending 15 runs in the final over to help the White Ferns secure a spot in the final, which they went on to win.

Alongside Lea Tahuu and Devine, this trio of 'Grandmas,' as they call themselves, played a crucial role in the Kiwis' journey to the champion's podium.

Stafanie Taylor batting through severe pain in her left knee, Harmanpreet Kaur's two half-centuries after taking a few knocks to the head during training, Chamari Athapaththu once again shouldering the responsibility for her Sri Lankan side, and Afy Fletcher being a no-fuss lethal weapon for the Windies are all great examples.

Meanwhile, young captains like Wolvaardt and Fatima Sana, and emerging talents like Eden Carson (New Zealand), Annabel Sutherland (Australia), Marufa Akter (Bangladesh), and Zaida James (West Indies) showed that while the vacuum left by the outgoing generation may not be entirely filled, the women's game does have exciting prospects for the future.

Big picture

Wider pools, more bilateral games outside the top eight in the rankings, and better opportunities for Associates to compete with full members internationally were major topics of discussion in the UAE.

Devine, at the very start of the tournament, had bounced off the idea of a tiered system of matches within the championship to provide Associate nations with more match time against higher-ranked opponents.

At its latest Board Meeting, the ICC approved the creation of two annual T20 International tournaments between 2025 and 2028 to allow the Associates a structured pathway into an expanded pool for World Cups.

